1121-098 GSM-gau (USMARC)
City of Savannah Office of Municipal Archives and History, Savannah, Georgia [GSG (OCLC/LYRASIS)]

Record Series #: 1121-098
Name: Pastor and Mrs. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Collection
Dates: 1920-2022, no date
Extent/Size: 1 document case; 1 oversized box; 1 oversized folder (1 cubic ft)
Language: English

Name of Creator:
Reverend Matthew Southall Brown, Sr.

Biographical History:
Reverend Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. (1922-2021) was born on July 16, 1922, in Savannah, Georgia, to Christopher Frederick Brown and Helen Robinson Brown. He was married to the late Mrs. Lottie Williams Brown for over 65 years, a union that produced four children. He had 36 grandchildren and great-grandchildren.

A decorated war veteran, Brown was among the first African Americans to desegregate the military and serve during World War II. He served with the 60th Infantry Regiment, 9th Infantry Division, Company E (a segregated support unit) and earned the Good Conduct Medal, WWII Victory Medal, and American Theater Ribbon, among other commendations.

After his military service, he attended Georgia State College and earned his Bachelor of Divinity degree from the American Baptist Seminary in Nashville, Tennessee. In 1961, he was ordained as a minister at the historic First African Baptist Church in Savannah.

Brown served several congregations before finding his longest and most impactful ministry. In 1969, he became pastor of St. John Baptist Church in Savannah, where he led the congregation through the church's renovation. Brown was also active in civil rights work in Savannah and was widely regarded by fellow faith leaders as the “pastor's pastor.” In 1970, he was selected to lead a biracial advisory committee to integrate Savannah's schools, and throughout his life he served as a guiding influence in civil rights affairs.

In 1986, he dedicated St. John Villa (formerly the East Broad Street School) as a housing complex for the elderly and the handicapped. In 1988, the Matthew Southall Brown Resources and Learning Center was named in his honor.

He hosted a local morning radio program called “Thought for the Day” and retired as pastor emeritus of St. John Baptist Church after 35 years in 2004. The National Baptist Convention recognized him in 2013 for more than 50 years of service.

Reverend Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., passed away on November 21, 2021, at the age of 99, from natural causes. His four children survive him: Maxine Jones, Leonard Brown, Christa Stephens, and Matthew Southall Brown Jr.

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Scope & Content:
The Pastor and Mrs. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Collection includes awards, recognitions, and plaques, photos of the Brown family and St. John Baptist Church, funeral programs [also available digitally], newspaper articles discussing the life of Reverend Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., an illustrated history of the Brown family, St. John Baptist Church memorabilia, buttons depicting election campaigns and St. John Baptist Church, a medal from the National Baptist Convention, sermons and notes written and delivered by Rev. Brown, Sr., VHS and cassette tapes [cassette tapes are also in digital format], books and vinyls from Rev. Brown, Sr.'s private collection, National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) items, and a nameplate. Highlights of the collection include: Original photos from St. John Baptist Church, an illustrated history of the Brown family's ancestry, four buttons depicting election campaigns and St. John Baptist Church, a typed script of the final scene from the play "Passion and Triumph of Jesus"—written by Dr. Ralph Mark Gilbert in 1952, original sermons written and delivered by Rev. Brown, Sr., and cassette tapes of Rev. Brown, Sr.'s sermons [also in digital format], a citizenship competency test, and Rev. Brown, Sr's NAACP membership card. Major themes include: St. John Baptist Church, Savannah religious history, civil rights, religion, and World War II veterans.

Custodial History:
The Pastor and Mrs. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Collection was donated to the Municipal Archives in 2024 by Leonard A. Brown. Additional materials continue to be maintained by the family.

System of Arranging & Ordering:
The Pastor and Mrs. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Collection is arranged by format and alphabetically by subject into twelve folders and three boxes. Please see the attached inventory and box contents list.

Related Collections:
Record series 1121-064.13 Cann Park Community Collection. City of Savannah Office of Municipal Archives and History, Savannah, Georgia.

GHS 2895 The Matthew Southall Brown Family Papers. Georgia Historical Society Manuscript Collection. Georgia Historical Society.

Conditions Governing Access:
None

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Digital Access:
The Pastor and Mrs. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Collection has been partially digitized. Items are available upon request.

Access Points:
African American religious leaders
African American veterans
Brown, Leonard A.
Chatham County Council of Colored Parent-Teacher Association—Georgia—Savannah
Churches—Georgia—Chatham County—Savannah—Baptist
Civil rights—Georgia—Savannah
Clergy—Georgia—Chatham County
National Association for the Advancement of Colored People—Georgia—Savannah
Performance—Religious aspects
Religion—Christianity—Baptist
Reverend Matthew Southall Brown, Sr.
St. John Baptist Church—Georgia—Savannah
United States—Armed Forces—African Americans
United States—Armed Forces—History—20th century—African Americans
World War II, 1939-1945—African Americans

Preferred Citation:
Record Series 1121-098, Pastor and Mrs. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Collection. City of Savannah Office of Municipal Archives and History, Savannah, Georgia.

Processed by:
A. Hutchinson, May 2026.

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Inventory:

Box 1121-098-0001

Box 1 Folders

Folder 1 - Awards and Recognitions, 2013-2018

1. Letter from Governor Nathan Deal recognizing Reverend Brown Sr.'s 50 years in the ministry. September 13, 2013.
2. Letter from Mayor Eddie W. DeLoach celebrating Reverend Brown Sr.'s 95th birthday. July 14, 2017.
3. Certificate of Appreciation for Reverend Brown Sr.'s work with the community outpatient clinic in Savannah and Black History Month. Given by the Department of Veterans Affairs on February 14, 2018.

Folder 2 - Brown Family records, 2004-2021, no date

1. "Community: Progress in the Midst of Oppression. 1923-2015." An illustrated booklet of the Brown family's ancestry.
2. A copy of a magazine article about Reverend Brown Sr.'s military service. No date.
3. Article about Leonard A. Brown receiving DeKalb County's Teacher of the Year. February 10, 2004.
4. Reverend Brown Sr.'s funeral program. Illustrated and dated December 4, 2021.

Folder 3- Buttons, 1991, no date

1. "Otis Johnson for Mayor."
2. "Re-elect Mayor Edna Jackson, Proven Leadership."
3. "Maintain a Tradition: Adopt a Child."
4. "St. John Baptist Church 100th Anniversary 1891-1991."

Folder 4 - Church Materials [includes St. John Baptist Church and Mount Pleasant Baptist Church], 1952-2006, no date

1. Laminated bookmark featuring Reverend Brown, Sr. and St. John Baptist Church
2. Funeral program for Ruth Jones Stripling. March 28, 2006
3. Activity guide for the Ralph Mark Gilbert Civil Rights Museum. No date.
4. Program for the 17th Annual Youth Crusade for Christ at Mount Pleasant Baptist Church. Reverend Brown Sr. was the main speaker. 1977.
5. Illustrated program for the "Passion and Triumph of Jesus" play at St. John Baptist Church. 2005.

6. A typed script of the final scene from the play "Passion and Triumph of Jesus." Written by Dr. Ralph Mark Gilbert. 1952.

Folder 5 – Medal, no date

1. National Honoree medal from the National Baptist Convention.

Folder 6- NAACP, 1954-1990s, no date

1. Photocopy of Rev. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr.'s NAACP membership card from 1954.
2. Photocopy of Pastor Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. and W. W. Law standing in front of Nicholsonboro Baptist Church in Sandfly before its restoration. Ca. 1990s.
3. Q&A for Citizenship Training Course, sponsored by the Savannah Branch NAACP. Competency Test practice in the event they were interrogated during voter registration. No date.

Folder 7 - Nameplate, no date

1. "Rev. Matthew Brown" nameplate

Folder 8 - Newspapers, 2011-2019

1. Hoskins, Charles Lwanga. "Pastor Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. (The Last of the Old School Fathers)." *Savannah Herald*. March 2, 2011.
2. Howard, Marcus E. "Dean of Clergyman Releases New Book." *Savannah Morning News.* September 30, 2013.
3. Brown, Leonard A. "Pastor Matthew Southall Brown, Sr. Returns from Belgium and The Netherlands." *The Savannah Tribune*. September 25, 2019.

Folder 9 - Photographs-Copies, ca. 1920s-2019, no date

1. Class graduation photo from Georgia State College. Circa 1920. Includes Mammie Brown Derrick (Rev. Brown Sr.'s aunt) and Joe Derrick (Mammie's husband)
2. Class graduation photo from Cuyler Senior High School. January 1943.
3. Pastor Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., Lottie Williams Brown, and Eva Robinson holding a baby (Maxine Brown). Standing in front of 927 West Victory Dr. in Savannah. 1949.
4. Christopher Brown, Sr. and Helen Robinson Brown (Reverend Brown Sr.'s parents) standing in front of homes on West Victory Dr. in Savannah. Circa 1950s.
5. Pastor Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., and Viola Robinson (his aunt) standing next to 925 West Victory Dr. in Savannah. Circa 1950s.
6. Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., circa 1960s.

7. The Brown Family. (Right to left: Maxine Brown Jones, Matthew Southall Brown, Jr., Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., Lottie Williams Brown (seated), Leonard A. Brown, and Christa Brown Stephens. Circa 1990s.
8. Reverend Brown, Sr., shaking hands with the Kings and Queens of Belgium and the Netherlands. 2019.
9. Magazine featuring Reverend Brown Sr.'s trip to Belgium and the Netherlands. Standing in front of a house.

Folder 10 - Photographs-Originals, ca. 1980s, no date

1. "Usher's Line." St. John Baptist Church, Savannah, Georgia. Circa 1980s. Black and white.
2. St. John Baptist Church congregation. Features Pastor Matthew Southall Brown, Sr., George Washington, Christopher Butler, Charles Brannon, and Velma Johnson (pianist). Circa 1980s. Black and white.
3. "3rd Sunday Communion Prayer." St. John Baptist Church. Circa 1980s. Black and white.
4. "3rd Sunday Choir." Features Ms. Truelle-Love, Ms. Perry, Mrs. Tyson, Mrs. Shephard, Mrs. Clara Bryant, and Mrs. Denmark in the front row. Photograph taken by Reverend E.O.S. Cleveland, 2nd Pastor. St. John Baptist Church. Black and white.
5. Reverend Brown Sr. and Mrs. Lottie Williams Brown, standing on the stairs. 1984. Colored image.
6. "A young member of the St. John Baptist Church receiving his commission from the Naval Academy." The image is in color and shows the Naval graduate shaking hands with President George W. Bush, from whom he received the commission. No date.
7. Reverend Brown Sr. is standing at a podium, in a robe, holding a Bible, preaching to a congregation. Colored image. No date.
8. Reverend Brown Sr. receiving an award. Colored image. No date.

Folder 11 - Sermons and Notes (Written and delivered by Reverend Matthew Southall Brown, Sr.), 1976-2016

1. "What Must I Do?" St. John Baptist Church. October 16, 1976.
2. "The Church of My Dream." St. John Baptist Church. 1993.
3. "A Warning from History or From the Past." St. John Baptist Church. April 2, 1995.
4. No Title. St. John Baptist Church. March 9, 1997.
5. "Follow Me." St. John Baptist Church. May 21, 2000.
6. "Installation Service for Rev. Marlind Worrell." St. John Baptist Church. November 24, 2002.

7. "123rd Anniversary of St. Thomas AME Church." March 20, 2011.
8. "8th Anniversary." Fifth Street Baptist Church Prayer Breakfast. May 5, 2012.
9. "FAB of E. S.—Thomas Williams—30th Anniversary." November 13. 2016.

Box 1121-098-0002

Box 2 Contents

Books:

1. Graham, B. J. W. *Ten Fundamental Doctrines*. (Atlanta: Index Printing Company, 1918).
2. *Saint John Baptist Church "The Mighty Fortress," Savannah, Georgia.* May 25, 1980. Book of the church's history.
3. *Saint John Baptist Church "The Mighty Fortress," 1891-1997*. Commemorative journal of the church's history.
4. Borders, William Holmes. *When the Bottom of Your Heart Drops Out. A Comparison of King, Gandhi, Lincoln, Moses, and Jesus.*
5. Edwards, Roberta. *Barack Obama: An American Story*. (New York: Grosset & Dunlap, 2008).
6. Brown, Leonard A. *A Commemorative Tribute to the Vision, the People, and the Legacy: Saint John Baptist Church 1969-2004.* (Orlando: 2022).

Cassette Tapes:

1. Brown, Matthew Southall, Sr. "What's Wrong with Same Sex Marriage?" July 23, 2004. [Digitized. Please ask a member of the Archives staff for access]
2. Brown, Matthew Southall, Sr. "The Storms Just Keep on Coming." September 5, 2004. [Digitized. Please ask a member of the Archives staff for access]

Plaques:

1. Plaque given to Reverend Brown from the Savannah Branch NAACP. *Gilbert/Law Lifelong Champions Award for Human and Civil Rights.* 2014.
2. Plaque given to Reverend Brown from the West Broad YMCA. *Heritage Hero Award for Community Activism and Service.* September 9, 2017.

VHS Tapes:

1. "Daufuskie Island." April 30, 2000.
2. Brown, Lottie Williams. "An Evening with Children and Youth." March 21, 2003.

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Vinyl Records:

1. "Your Arms Too Short to Box with God." Vinnette Carroll's Broadway. (New York: ABC Records, Inc., 1977).
2. "Goodbye, September." The Savannah Community Choir, directed by E. Larry McDuffie. (Nashville: Nashboro Records, 1981).

Oversized Folder 1121-098-0003 [housed in box 1121-000-0006]

1. Reproduction of a color image of the Savannah Branch, NAACP, in the Georgia State Capitol. Standing at the bottom left are W. W. Law and State Representative Bobby Hill. Signed by W. W. Law, 1972.